United vs Real Madrid. I hadn't taped it. When I'd left home eight hours earlier I'd had other things on my mind. This was a second broadcast of the whole game. I slurped my noodles and settled into it. The hat-trick. The free-kick and scrambling my second goal. The free-kick I'd missed: I was annoyed with myself, watching it. But then the camera cut away to the manager's reaction and my blood ran cold. He was craning his neck, watching. He turned away as the ball went over the bar. Then, when he looked back, his face just told me everything I needed to know. His rage, his frustration: and it was all Beckham's fault. He reacted as if I'd just lost us the game. As if, in that moment, I'd just got us knocked out of the Champions League. Maybe anybody watching the television would have seen the same. Maybe you needed to have lived through the past six months to really understand what was obvious to me:

'It's over. He wants me out.'

Something sank in as I sat there with the last few minutes of the game flickering past on the screen. The manager had had enough. I'd grown up as a person and he didn't seem to like what I'd become. I already knew that, deep down. Now it looked like he'd seen enough of me as a player, as well. As a player wearing a United shirt, anyway. His face in the seconds after I'd missed that second free-kick made me feel like a door had just been slammed in mine. I'd been flying all evening. I genuinely believed what I'd done during the game would force a way back in for me. No chance. If it was anything to do with the boss—and, of course, it would be—I was sure I was finished.

There were three League games before the end of the season: three games to win to make sure United took back the title. I played every minute of those three games: away to Spurs, at home to Charlton and away to Everton. The rumors that had me going to the Bernabeu kept circulating. The manager had said he'd thought they'd disappear once the quarter-final was out of the way. They didn't. It seems with some stories, once they get a head of steam on, they have a life of their own. We won 2–0 at Tottenham and, between then and the next match, there were quotes from Spanish newspapers saying Real weren't going to buy me.

'Never. Never. Never.'

The next day, everybody was saying that 'No' obviously meant 'Yes'. Hadn't Real said they weren't going to buy Ronaldo a year ago, too? I won't pretend that the attention that I was supposed to be getting from Real, and